

So the purpose of communicating about money in your marriage is to bring you closer together, to teach you more about trusting God, to create a oneness, and to free your minds.

10 A WORKABLE PLAN

Some years ago I was counseling a couple I'll call Keith and Laura who were having difficulty controlling their spending. During the first counseling session I said, "I want you to go home and develop a budget together. But," I warned, "don't try to correct three years of bad habits in the next three months. You can't do that. Also, don't create a budget that's so restrictive that it allows nothing for entertainment and recreation, clothing, and so on."

When they returned about two months later, I asked Keith, "How do you like your budget so far?"

He said, "This is the greatest. I love it. We have our finances under control for the first time ever."

Then I asked Laura, "How do you like your budget so far?"

She replied, "This is absolutely the worst thing that has ever happened in my life."

"Why do you say that?" I asked.

"Do you remember talking to us about controlling our expenses and writing everything down?"

"Sure."

"And you said that we have to learn to control our miscellaneous, right?" (Miscellaneous is that category that eats up all of your money and you can never remember where it went.)

"Sure."

"Well, the thing that you didn't realize is that *my* hair is miscellaneous, *my* car is miscellaneous, *my* clothes are miscellaneous." She went through all the things that Keith considered miscellaneous and should be eliminated from the budget.

"But," she continued, "one thing that is not miscellaneous is his bass boat. That's a necessity of life. A new deer rifle—that's not miscellaneous. That's a necessity of life. You know,"